

21 UP ↑ I RAJ CHENGAPPA

Lessons from Pune

When two people, one carrying a haversack, walked into the German Bakery, a popular restaurant frequented by the young in the heart of Pune, there should have been at least a guard who could have frisked them or a metal detector at the doorway to sound the alert. Inside, the Bakery's CCTV was apparently focused only on the cash counter and - didn't monitor the rest of the eatery. If such precautions were in place they may have saved 11 lives on February 13 and not reignited the wave of fear caused by the first big terror strike after Mumbai 26/11 in 2008.

Yet, we don't seem to have learnt one of the major lessons of 26/11: that we as citizens should also play a key supportive role to the police's task of making our cities safer. This is not to absolve the Pune Police or the state and Centre of the blame of not thwarting the terror strike. Despite major changes that Union Home Minister P. Chidambaram has effected at the Centre to bolster India's response to terror, states have moved sluggishly to implement reform. Local policemen are still poorly paid, ill-equipped and shabbily trained. The stations they work in are grossly understaffed and intelligence gathering weak. So should we then wait for the state government to revamp the police setup—a process that may take over a decade—and till then do nothing ourselves?

Clearly, the answer is no. If each of us has invested in better locks for our doors, hired guards and set up a neighbourhood watch system to protect our homes, then private

security measures. Private policing agencies now employ over five million guards, much more than all the police forces. Yet the bulk of them offer rudimentary protection and are hamstrung by outdated laws and procedures that prevent them from having better coordination with the regular police forces. They could prove to be a major second line of defence for the embattled police forces, providing the necessary manpower and intelligence network that could thwart Pune-type attacks. Yet many states are still to implement the 2005 Private Security Act. Also the Act has some stifling ambiguities that have to be removed. The Centre and states need to urgently work out how best private security agencies can be a force multiplier against terror. Private policing may not stop terror strikes but it will help in thwarting many of them.



SAURABH SINGH/www.indiatodayimages.com



SIGNPOSTS

APPOINTED: Indian-American **Rashad Hussain** as the US envoy to the 57-member Organisation of Islamic Conference to deepen and expand US partnerships with Muslims around the world.



CERTIFIED: Palakkad in Kerala as the first district in India to be fully electrified with every household even in remote tribal areas getting electricity.

DIED: Sikkim's first Lok Sabha MP **Santosh Kumar Rai**, one of the signatories of the 1973 agreement that led to the merger of Sikkim with the Union of India. He was a Lok Sabha member from 1975 to 1979.

DIED: Islamic scholar and educationist **C.M. Abdullah Moulavi**, 75. He was the Kerala unit vice-president of the Jamiat-ul-Ulema and the founder of the Malabar Islamic Complex that runs educational bodies.

